



More PS exclusives on PC?

Sony have said on a corporate report that they're open to releasing more first-party games on PC. <http://digit.in/sep20-87>



Animated X-Files spin-off

Fox is developing an animated X-Files comedy spin-off that will feature a team of misfit agents. <http://digit.in/sep20-88>

Boo Zoom

You know I had to get to this eventually

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The first time Ed asked me to write something about Zoom was back in April, but I flat out refused to do it, or join the Zoom meeting link that he sent me. Eventually I succumbed, not because of the demands of the job, but the demands of family that insisted on staying connected even though our only real interactions were speculations around which is the next niece or nephew to get married. Frankly, it can get a little boring at times listening to a bunch of old farts boasting about which tech company their progeny has managed to get into, which is unfortunately less competitive than outgrowing each other's nostril hair. Anyway, the main thing is that the family suddenly insisted on weekend Zoom sessions, for no good rhyme or reason. That allowed me to experience the range of trials and tribulations that a typical Zoom user goes through. The first half an hour is spent in making sure everyone can hear each other clearly (which is a futile exercise for a bunch of geriatrics with dementia denial). After that people finally begin to chat, but invariably someone goes off, someone has a power cut, someone else manages to join with two devices, then there is an echo, the host has to mute the household with the noisy kids... the list just goes on.

Eventually the demands of the lockdown meant that I had to start using Zoom professionally as well, including having to click on those pretentious

custom domain names. Has anyone looked at a Zoom invite? I mean really what's with all those numbers and options? Does anyone even use all that? Just provide a single link for Hawking's sake and call it a day! Whenever I use any software, I do a few things that most people just don't seem to care about. I always make it a point to read the license agreement very carefully. Then, I always make it a point to choose a unique password for the service. I always keep the software updated, and I always read the changelogs. Zoom seems to be obsessed with pushing out updates, as there were twelve of them in the month of August alone! Surprisingly enough, these are actual features that someone may find useful, and not just customary "bug fixes". Hidden deep in these notes are some perplexing features that just go to show the kind of insane demands that people have from the service. Do you know what the maximum duration of a Zoom call is? It used to be twenty four hours, but was extended to thirty. I don't even want to speculate on the utility of that. Then, they added Facebook style reaction emojis, for the more casual users I guess. There are now sliders for automatic touch up and lighting... and the former option just makes your video look low res in an effort to blur out the wrinkles. Needless to say, it did not work on the grandfathers of tech giant employees. Then there are some outright creepy features. Account owners can surreptitiously listen in to calls that they have set up, without the participants being aware of the eavesdropper in their midst. Employees, be



warned, and bosses, send the thanks to my inbox. Then over a matter of a few days, GIPHY integration was first removed and then added. Did you know that Zoom has GIPHY integration? Well, now you know.

As if fakebook was not enough, now we have another platform where people are forced to turn into something that they are not. The fake backgrounds, the attempts at competitive book shelving, the efforts to look smart only from the waist up, the artificial plants to add to the decor, the half hearted attempts at piling all the clutter in the house out of camera view... all of these behavioral changes in people are mildly irritating and totally predictable. I thought towards the end of 2020 people would have been tired of wearing masks, but apparently not.

It does not matter whether it is Zoom or some other video conferencing service, there are three things that happen in every call.

1. Someone is going to get yelled at for being on mute, and that person is going to continue to talk without realising it.
2. Someone is going to point the camera or the webcam at the ceiling fan, and leave it in that position for the duration of the meeting.
3. Someone is going to join from two devices, or the software and the browser, and get thoroughly confused about what is going on.

There is a simple and time tested solution to fix the problem with video conferencing. Just don't do it. Use the phone service, conference calls work just fine. The biggest danger to society is not really the software itself, but the normalisation of video calling. Over the past few months an out of work taxi driver, my milkman and my electrician have given me WhatsApp video calls. Just, no, thanks. 